



Adille Sumariwalla, Vice President of World Athletics, Raghuram Iyer, CEO of Indian Olympic Association, and Senior Reporter Dhruva Prasad at the Sportstar Focus Bihar Conclave. THE HINDU

‘There are six others who are in the fray’ — Raghuram Iyer

Team Sportstar

Raghuram Iyer, CEO of the Indian Olympic Association, named the six other countries that are presently interested in hosting the 2036 Olympics during the *Sportstar Focus Bihar Conclave*.

“We were recently in a meeting with potential future hosts. There are six others who are in the fray. I can name the ones in the meeting room. The countries are Chile, Turkey, Qatar, South Korea, and Hungary. Germany was also present,” Iyer said.

Adille Sumariwalla, vice-president of World Athletics, stressed that there are a number of factors that need to be accounted for before India can go full-throttle on its Summer Games hosting ambitions.

“They are looking at temperatures, air quality, sustainability, and legacy. Also, is this actually going to give a boost to the nation? Is your medal count going to improve? Things like that are very important. Money, everyone will show, but these soft skills are what matter. Where are your volunteers? You need 40,000 volunteers. Are you going to do it all in one place where the weather is too hot? Or will you shift to somewhere where it is a bit more pleasant? The

most important factor is the dates. Between July and August, it is warm in India,” Sumariwalla said.

Sumariwalla, however, clarified that the country, purely in terms of hosting capabilities, can do an excellent job. “This is a misnomer that we don’t host events properly. Okay, badminton [India Open] was an aberration. I can tell you the Commonwealth Games that we organised in India were the best ever. I have been to at least half a dozen of them. The food, the accommodation, the transport, the technical conduct, the hospitality, the airport, and the visas. Absolutely outstanding. In terms of delivery, there is no issue.”

Iyer, when asked to realistically evaluate India’s chances of getting to secure the hosting rights of the 2036 Games, said, “The biggest reason for confidence in India is, can you ignore the 700 million youth below the age of 25?

“The Olympics itself is looking to make an impact. It resonates with their story. There are small concerns; people are talking about the weather because for the athletes, comfort is a major factor. It’s too early to know whether we are in pole position or not, but we are definitely in the race.”

